

Giving and Receiving Critique on Scientific Work

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What is Critique?

- Identifying things you really love
- A collaboration with the author
- A gift of your attention
- Identifying areas for improvement

How to Read for Critique

- Go in with an understanding of their goals (or requirements) and see if the piece meets them
 - Do they answer the questions they set out in the intro?
- The author's job is to communicate clearly to you—note where you get stuck or need to reread!
- Everyone has worthwhile feedback to provide—perspective on what is hard to understand is often the most helpful!
- You don't necessarily need to understand the details of the methods, but you should understand the whys

How to Write for Critique

- Your own notes on a paper and critique for the author are usually not the same (especially in tone)
- Sandwich method: at least one positive comment to start, then constructive feedback, ending on a positive note
- Summarize your takeaways as a reader—are those what the author hoped to convey?
- Explain the reasoning behind your suggestions when possible. This helps the author understand your logic, and how they might make a different modification to address the concern if your suggestion doesn't work for them
 - You can also link to outside sources that affected your thinking on the topic

What is Good Critique? (i.e., Who to Listen To)

- Be selective about what feedback you take to heart!
- Is this person interested in making the work better?
- Is this person valuing you and your ideas (even if they are challenging some of them!)?

Receiving Critique: Mental

- Manage your expectations! It is not uncommon for a piece to go through 10+ revisions. Working through feedback is the natural next step in that process, not any failure of the previous version.
- Try to separate the feeling of being grateful for thorough feedback from any overwhelm at the work it suggests
- Remind yourself why you asked for the feedback
 - Multiple perspectives improve things a lot faster than working alone

- It is better to hear things early from your community than later in a paper/grant review

Receiving Critique: Logistical

- Change the big, structural things first—you might not even keep that sentence you are agonizing over
- If you received feedback from multiple people at once, compile it
 - Find the big picture takeaways
 - Color coding by person can help
 - Remember, only take what is useful! If feedback conflicts, go with whatever makes sense for the trajectory of the project more broadly and move forward with that.

This work is hard! You're doing great.

Thanks to: Jacquelyn Fitzgerald, Josh Scholl, Sam Rosa, Alex Zink, Vicky DeLira, Elsa Godtfredsen, Brayden Saunders, Paul CaraDonna, Amy Iler, and Ceci Rigby